

RR 2017/034**The Cambridge Handbook of Western Mysticism and Esotericism***Edited by Glenn Alexander Magee*

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Growing modern participation in forms of generic spirituality has encouraged widespread interest in divine insight and illumination. Sociologists and theologians have noted the impact of this cultural change on the popular imagination, as well as on traditional faith claims and allegiances. In parallel with this, there has been growth in forms of investigative and interpretative scholarship into Western mysticism and the esoteric. This has a clear and strong historical and historiographic side, as many of the strands and themes extend back beyond the Middle Ages to ancient times.

It has also been a field where academic and populist approaches have been mixed up in glorious confusion, one including scholarly work on the Kabbalah and mystics such as Boehme and Gurdjieff, Hildegard of Bingen and Sufism, Jung and the “via negativa” (where we strive to unself the self to come close to what we regard as the divine), gematria and the hidden mystery of numbers, mesmerism and healing, Paraselsian alchemical transformation and astrology. Because this area of research and practice, intellectual inquiry and popular credulity is so fluid and controversial, critical approaches in themselves attract skepticism and sometimes scorn. For these and other reasons, the editor of the excellent handbook, Glenn Magee (Long Island University), alerts readers to the fact that mysticism and esotericism play the role of an alternative narrative in Western thinking – alternative to scientific inquiry (pre- and post-Enlightenment), alternative to traditional religious paradigms and practices and alternative to medical and clinical knowledge in claims about healing and well-being.

At the heart of both strands here – the “mainstream” and the “alternative” (both terms worth deconstructing, as they are here) – is interest in and the search for forms of “knowledge” or “gnosis”. This may be the “divine” knowledge claimed by Hermes Trismegistus in the Hermetic tradition, which

itself extends back to early Gnosticism (where salvation came through acquiring such knowledge), or the “noesis” (knowledge of good truth) claimed by Orphism and the mystical experience of the One-Good argued for in Neo-Platonism, or the harmony between human beings and God advocated by Swedenborg and his followers or by Steiner’s anthroposophy, or getting close to nature in the form of sacred pantheism in current neo-paganism.

All these forms of knowledge interweave with the Western experience of the divine and in turn draw on numerous forms of “Eastern” beliefs and practices too. The “knowledge” or “insight” or “illumination”, then, is as likely to have been shaped by Buddhist and Hindu ideas as by accounts of ecstatic or intuitive encounters with the divine, as described by medieval mystics and saints. We think of Jung and his interest in the *Book of the Dead* and the I Ching, Blavatsky’s Buddhist ideas in her writings such as *Isis Unveiled*, the Tantric sex-magic of Crowley and Thelema, the return to God through inner illumination in Sufism and how Gurdjieff argued that we are asleep and inauthentic beings in disharmony with cosmic forces, and perhaps above all the blended beliefs of Guénon and Coomaraswamy’s “perennial religion” with its implications for political power. These cross-currents come through clearly in a series of 36 essays in the handbook, explaining and unpacking definitions and critical approaches, as likely to discuss how Christian evangelists used the Kabbalah to “convert” the Jews as comment on the response of the secular scientific world (now and at the time of the Enlightenment and before) to the “transformation” claims of Rosicrucians (whose magic knowledge or “sapientia” and belief in the philosophers’ stone helped to shape Masonic practice).

There have been times when collisions between alternative and mainstream have persisted – the debate about the animal magnetism of Mesmer (1734-1815) reveals how at the time spiritists manipulated somnambulist healing into criminal deceptions but how by implication the psychotherapeutic claims made by current practitioners benefit from our taking a historical perspective. The ghost photos and mediumistic trances so loved by Conan Doyle are present currently, as a look at angelology literature in “mind-body-spirit” sections of a good book-store will confirm. The handbook provides a wealth of critical and historical material – antiquity (Pythagoras, Platonism, Hermeticism and Jewish mysticism), the Middle Ages and the Renaissance (medieval mysticism, humanism, the Christian Kabbalah, Boehme’s complex ideas about the unself and how we move from darkness into light and come to see God) through Swedenborg and Mesmer to the modern period with spiritualism

and theosophy, Steiner and the Golden Dawn, Jung and contemporary paganism. There is a final section on common themes such as gnosis and astrology, mathematical esotericism and panpsychism.

Contributors to this handbook are world-class – writers such as Wouter Hanegraaff and Kocku von Stuckrad, Antoine Faivre and Arthur Versluis. Each has written magisterially about the content and place of mysticism and esotericism, making this not merely an arcane field of intellectual inquiry but a living and contended area where theologians and historians, anthropologists and students of cultural and religious history engage and should do so. As exemplars of inquiry in their own right, the essays are excellent, thoughtfully expressed and contentious where they need to be, unpacking complex ideas such as those of Boehme and Swedenborg elegantly. The work is aimed at the academic and research environment, but there is much also for the common reader – above all someone exploring the eclectic frontiers of spirituality currently and wondering where some of the “strange ideas” come from. At its extreme, mysticism and esotericism is a field where wild things are said and done: it is good for the discipline that such works as the handbook enable us to examine things dispassionately and historically. That process allows us all to reflect on what we know and believe and what we believe our place in the scheme of things really is.

Stuart Hannabuss

*Independent Reviewer and Researcher,
Aberdeen, UK*

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The Oxford Dictionary of Philosophy (3rd edition)

Simon Blackburn

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Since first publication in 1994, *The Oxford Dictionary of Philosophy* by Simon Blackburn has been the best short alphabetic guide to philosophy. There was a second edition in 2005, revised in 2008, and it now reaches a third edition. That second edition was an expansion of the first. It is not clear how much this third edition has grown. In his preface, Simon Blackburn comments that he has removed some more exotic references on the grounds that information about obscure figures can be found on the internet (and these remain in the online version of the dictionary). On the other hand, he says that he added more philosophical detail and a number of new entries. One of the virtues of the dictionary has been to give definition from outside academic philosophy, and this continues here with space for economic terms and principles – as Blackburn says, to reflect debates following the financial collapse of 2008 – and with expanded entries on the philosophy of law, “bearing in mind the increased prominence of failed states and civil war”. The blurb further claims there have been new entries on social theory and neuroscience.

A completely new device is the use of indicators for some entries, that is, small icons to, first, indicate terms that beginners in philosophy should know and, second, for specialized terms that anyone claiming to be educated in philosophy should know. Some other entries have an indicator directing users of the dictionary wanting more information to the *Oxford Reference* website. There is also a ten-page chronology of philosophical events.

What has not changed is the clarity and concision of the entries, and a certain dry humour that makes this volume a pleasure to browse, as well as its accuracy and informativeness. For an example of humour, the word *Kleptoparasitism*, a term from biology for parasitic creatures that live by stealing what other creatures have provided for themselves, is invoked as a metaphor for many bankers and fund managers. The *Selfie* is analysed in two succinct sentences. For clarity and concision, the half page on *Relativism* is a model. Every student in philosophy should have this, as well as anyone interested in philosophy.

Michel Petheram

*Previously Associate Lecturer Open University
and former Reference Librarian, London, UK*

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